



Picture perfect: Vijay Amritraj with his family members. "This is not just an honour for me, my parents, and my family, but for my fellow Indians and my country," he said. PICTURE COURTESY: ITHF

right parents," Vijay said. "My biggest sadness, I would say, is them not being here with me to be able to share this. But it has been such a monumental task and effort on their part to get me into this situation and make something of me, which I never dreamt about."

Among his memorabilia on display are his Rolex watch from his 1976 victory here in Newport, his ITF Golden Achievement Award, the key to the city of Los Angeles, the Padma Shri medallion, and his World Championship Tennis jacket.

Welcoming Amritraj, Leander and veteran tennis journalist Richard Evans, a chronicler of 200 Majors and the biographer of Amritraj, to the illustrious club were many of the game's greatest and fellow Hall of Famers, including 18-time Grand Slam winner Christ Evert, her greatest rival and friend Navratilova, Andre Agassi, Stan Smith, and WTA founding member Rosie Casals.

The Indians, in vibrant sarees and crisp bandhgalas, were everywhere,

outnumbering the more stoic, buttoned-up members of the club. It was a splash of Bollywood into an old-school English tea party, and the setting was chaotically beautiful.

Navratilova introduced Leander, the 18-time Grand Slam winner, as the player who played tennis "the way most of us would like to play." "He has got that off-speed serve, the big forehand, and the sliced backhand where it lands exactly where you don't want to land. When he comes to the net, he has a big forehand volley and reflexes like a leopard. He runs every ball down, and if he can't, he dives for it. And if all else fails, he smiles, and then everybody's heart melts," Navratilova said. "Leander, it was truly my honour to play against you. I enjoyed it a lot more when I played with you. You have done your family proud; you have done our sport proud; and most of all, you have done India proud."

Leander, dressed in a cream-coloured sherwani and the Padma Shri and Padma Bhushan proudly pinned to his lapel, said: "It is a privilege to be on this stage with these people who have inspired me every single day of my life. They are not just Grand Slam winners, but they have shaped the world we live

in. I thank all of you for giving this Indian boy hope."

Amritraj, winner of 28 tour-level titles, including three in Newport, was introduced by his son Prakash, who called him "my greatest hero, who also happens to be my father."

Amritraj reached the Wimbledon singles quarterfinals as a 19-year-old in 1973 and was the president of the ATP between 1989 and 1993. He became the first Asian to join the ITHF in the contributor category. "When I was given the news that this year I would be inducted, a feeling came over me that I had never experienced. Tennis has allowed me to meet people I never thought I would meet, and it has given me more things than I could have ever imagined.

It will always be a part of our lives and always bring families, communities, and countries together," Amritraj said. "This is not just an honour for me, my parents, and my family, but for my fellow Indians and my country."

With the Tiranga flying high atop the old Casino Building and bhangra moves breaking out to AP Dhillon's 'Brown Munde', it was unmistakably India's day in Newport. The two Brown Mundes had made the country proud.